

20 February 2026

Guideline for the Application of a License to Install, Use, Operate, and Apply for Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI)

The purpose of this document is to guide applicants seeking a license to install and use Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI) equipment. It outlines the necessary processes involved in applying for a license, the required supporting documents, and safety requirements. This guideline represents the minimum standards set forth by the South African Health Products Regulatory Authority (SAHPRA) for submitting applications to install and use MRI equipment.

MRI systems are regulated under the Hazardous Substances Act (Act 15 of 1973) and its subsequent regulations. According to Section 4(c) of the Hazardous Substances Act, any individual or company wishing to use, operate, apply, install, or store an MRI machine—whether for medical or non-medical purposes—must apply for a license in accordance with this guide. Before an MRI system can be installed and used, it must be licensed for import or manufacturing, and the application for technical evaluation will only be considered afterward. There is a separate guideline for obtaining a license to import listed electronic products, as described in Regulation 1302 of the schedule for listed electronic products.

The application form for obtaining a license to install and use MRI equipment can be found on the SAHPRA website.

Document History

Final Version	Reason for Amendment	Effective Date [01 March 2026]
1	-First issue	30 February 2026
2		

DR BOITUMELO SEMETE-MAKOKOTLELA
CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER

Contents

Document History.....	1
Glossary	3
1. INTRODUCTION	4
1.1 Purpose	4
1.2 Scope	4
2. LEGAL PROVISION	4
a. Hazardous Substances Act 15 of 1973	4
b. Regulation 1302 on Schedule of listed electronic products.	4
3. APPLICATION PROCESS.	5
3.1 Application Form.	5
3.2 Supporting documentation	5
4. ACKNOWLEDGEMENT AND REJECTION OF THE APPLICATION	6
5. VALIDITY AND RENEWAL OF THE USE LICENSE FOR MRI	7
6. COMMISSIONING AND ACCEPTANCE TESTS OF MRI	7
6.1 Acceptance Tests.....	7
6.2 Acceptance Tests by the applicant.....	7
6.3 Quality Assurance program.....	8
7. MRI SAFETY SIGNS.....	8
8. REFERENCES	9
9. VALIDITY	9

Glossary

Abbreviation/ Term	Meaning
MRI	Magnetic Resonance Imaging
SAHPRA	South African Health Products Regulatory Authority
RF	Radiofrequency
HAS Act	Hazardous Substances Act 15 of 1973

1. INTRODUCTION

The installation, use, and operation of Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI) machines are regulated by the Radiation Control Unit of the South African Health Products Authority, in accordance with the Hazardous Substances Act 15 of 1973. MRI machines are listed under section 5.11 of Regulation 1302, which includes a schedule of electronic products that are controlled and regulated for use. This also covers the installation, application, and maintenance of these devices, as detailed in section 4 of the Hazardous Substances Act.

MRI machines pose risks of exposing the public to strong magnetic fields and radiofrequency (RF) waves. These risks can lead to issues such as the malfunctioning of implanted medical devices, burns from heating, and projectile hazards from ferromagnetic objects, among others.

To minimize these risks, the Radiation Control Unit of the South African Health Products Authority aims to ensure compliance with the regulations and safety requirements surrounding the use, operation, and application of MRI machines.

1.1 Purpose

The purpose of this guideline is to ensure that the installation and use of MRI equipment comply with safety regulations. Additionally, the guideline aims to improve and enhance public safety by minimizing exposure to magnetic fields during the operation and application of MRI equipment.

1.2 Scope

To assist the applicant in applying for a license to install, use and operate MRI equipment, including the required supporting documents and necessary safety regulations to that must be followed.

2. LEGAL PROVISION

- a. Hazardous Substances Act 15 of 1973
- b. Regulation 1302 on Schedule of listed electronic products.

3. APPLICATION PROCESS

3.1 Application Form

Any individual or entity wishing to install, use, operate, or apply MRI equipment for either medical or non-medical purposes must apply for a license through the Radiation Control Unit of SAHPRA. To initiate this process, applicants must complete the prescribed application form found on the link <https://www.sahpra.org.za/radiation-control-application-and-report-forms/>.

The completed, signed, and dated application form should be submitted in PDF format to the email address nirmed.application@sahpra.org.za. It is essential that the application clearly includes the following information:

- a) The physical address of the premises (Hospital or Diagnostic practice)
- b) Contact details of the person responsible (including telephone and email address)
- c) Information about the reporting radiologist (including the latest HPSCA number)
- d) Details of qualified MRI radiographers (including the latest HPSCA number)
- e) A description of the MRI equipment (including model and Tesla levels)
- f) Serial Number of the machine (It must be provided to the regulator when machine is delivered, if not available when application is sent)
- g) The product model import license number (which must be provided by the suppliers)

3.2 Supporting documentation

The prescribed completed, signed, and dated application form must be sent to the Radiation Control unit of SAHPRA using the email address nirmed.application@sahpra.org.za accompanied by the following documentation:

- a. Professional registration supporting documentation
 - HPSCA Certification of the reporting/responsible Radiologist
 - HPSCA Certification of the responsible MRI Radiographer

b. Technical Supporting Documentation

- Premises layout sketches
- Layout Sketches indicating magnetic fields around the MRI machine premises
- Acceptance and Installation Tests after the installation are completed.
- Any supporting documentation may be instructed.

4. ACKNOWLEDGEMENT AND REJECTION OF THE APPLICATION

- Upon receipt of a completed application form for a license to install and use MRI, including all required supporting documents, the applicant will receive an acknowledgment confirming the receipt of the application.
- The model of the MRI machine applied must be licensed for importation.
- The application will be subjected to the screening, evaluation, and approval processes with a timeframe of 60 working days.
- After the technical evaluation of the application, the applicant will be sent an email informing them to proceed with the installation.
- Depending on the technical evaluation results of the submitted supporting documents, the regulator might request to perform the pre inspections.
- When the application is approved, the Regulator will inform the applicant through an email
- If the application came through with incorrect or incomplete supporting documents, the Regulator would send an email to the applicant requesting the complete/correct documentation to be submitted.
- The applicant will have five (10) working days to submit the correct supporting documents from the day they receive the email from Regulator about incorrect or complete documents.
- If the applicant has not responded to the Regulator with correct supporting documents within the allocated timeframe, they will receive a reminder.

- j. If the applicant has not responded to the regulator with correct supporting documents within 30 working days from when the application was received, the applications will be considered unsuccessful, and communication will be sent to the applicant regarding this within 10 working days.

5. VALIDITY AND RENEWAL OF THE USE LICENSE FOR MRI

- a. The use license of MRI will be valid for five (5) years.
- b. The license will be renewable within 90 (3 months) working days before the expiry date.
- c. The applicant must follow the steps in section 3 for submission of the application to renew.
- d. The renewal application will be subjected to the steps in Section 4.
- e. The applicant will be issued with communication confirming the submission of the application to renew and referred to technical evaluation and assessment.

6. COMMISSIONING AND ACCEPTANCE TESTS OF MRI

6.1 Acceptance Tests

The applicant must keep a file of acceptance tests that are performed as part of the installation and commissioning of MRI equipment in preparation of the equipment for clinical usage. The following minimum tests must be performed:

- a. Shielding tests,
- b. Electrical safety tests,
- c. Confirmation of the magnetic field 0.5mT (5 Gauss),
- d. Confirmation of the noise level among others

The applicant or licence holder must arrange that their technical representative(s) are involved or present during the performance of the commissioning and acceptance tests.

6.2 Acceptance Tests by the applicant

In addition to the tests performed by the supplier of the MRI equipment, an applicant must perform tests to ensure the following:

- a. Independent assessment of the performance of the MRI machine
- b. To create a file of baseline tests for regular quality assurance of the MRI machine
- c. To identify any corrective action before the commencement of the clinician use of the machine

6.3 Quality Assurance Programme

The applicant will be responsible for compiling a policy of a quality assurance programme, which includes, but is not limited to:

- a. Screening protocols,
- b. Imaging protocols,
- c. Tests for MRI quality image,
- d. Geometrical parameters
- e. Signal noise among others.
- f. MRI routine quality control tests

7. MRI SAFETY

- a. The licence holder will be responsible for ensuring the safety of the staff, patients, and public in and around the MRI premises.
- b. The licence holder must ensure that the MRI room has access control.
- c. The licence holder must ensure that the premises are correctly demarcated for access control.
- d. The licence holder must ensure that warning signs are clearly displayed at entrance.



Figure 1: MRI entry warning

8. REFERENCES

The following related documents are referenced:

1. Hazardous Substances Act 15 of 1973
2. International standards commission standards and guidelines for MRI accreditation
3. MHRI safety guidelines for MRI equipment in clinical use
4. HMRI MRI safety guidelines manual and safety procedures

9. VALIDITY

This guideline is valid for a period of five (5) years from the effective date of revision and replaces the [Old document title if applicable here/ and old document number]. It will be reviewed in this timeframe or as and when required.